Leagues Apart

by Jane Nicolaas



Leagues Apart by Jane Nicolaas

ISBN: 978-1-61387-032-7

Copyright 2010 by SpeechGeek.

Free performance of this play for high school and college level competitive forensics is permitted. All other rights reserved.

This PDF version of this selection, e-published in 2011, is identical to the printed published version of this same publication dated 2011. This statement along with the entire printed PDF of this publication must be presented at any National Forensic League District or National event for the script to comply with NFL rules per the request of the Executive Director.

This and other selections of quality performance literature for competitive oral interpretation are published by SpeechGeek.

For more information and performance rights, contact **SpeechGeek.**

SpeechGeek
806 Brownstone Way
Bowling Green, KY 42104

Phone: 1-888-742-2028
Email: thegeek@speechgeek.com
Web: www.speechgeek.com
Facebook: www.facebook.com/speechgeek

(A Negro League baseball game in Missouri. Satchel is on the pitching mound and Josh is approaching the plate as the batter.)

RADIO. Ladies and gentlemen, it's a great spring day in 1945 and that means one thing and one thing only: baseball. Today's Negro League All-Star game features some of the greatest colored players in the game: Satchel Paige and Josh Gibson.

JOSH. (*swings the bat as he approaches the plate*) There he is: Satchel Paige. So good he could strike out Jim Crow.

SATCH. (*loosens up his pitching arm*) And the Black Babe Ruth, Josh Gibson. How many homeruns you got, boy?

JOSH. Ask me again after I get this next one off of you.

SATCH. You can't hit what you can't see.

JOSH. Good one, old man! Sure sweet of you to climb out of your rocking chair to come play baseball with us?

SATCH. Yeah, Big Man. You keep talking while I strike you out. (*pitch*) What was that? Strike one?

JOSH. You gonna need two more 'fore you can start bragging.

SATCH. Yeah, alright. I'm just waking up.

JOSH. I got something to wake you up.

SATCH. (*pitch*) That looked like number two. I don't know. I mean, I *am* old. My eyes ain't what they used to be. Was that number two?

JOSH. Quit your showboating and pitch that ball. I get sick of you sometimes. Messing around. Not today.

SATCH. (*pitch*)

JOSH. (*hit*) Oooo-ee. That looks pretty, don't it?

SATCH. Damn man, I think that would have gone out of Yankee Stadium.

JOSH. Someday it will, I think.

SATCH. Yeah.

INTRO

RADIO. Now from the world of sports: On this day, April 3, 1945, Major League Baseball Owner Mr.

Branch Rickey has announced the formation of the Brooklyn Brown Dodgers.

(Transition to a clubhouse where Satch is kneeling by a radio, fascinated by the news. Josh limps in behind him, beat up.)

SATCH. (*not looking at Josh*) Oooooee! Did you hear that?

JOSH. And what makes you think they interested in you?

SATCH. I say white folks is crazy, not stupid. If Rickey wants to fill that ballpark, he gonna need Satchel Paige.

JOSH. Huh? (*winces*)

SATCH. (*looks at Josh*) Man, what the hell done happen to your face?

JOSH. These barnstorming games we've playing are all well and good at paying to feed my family, but they also a good way to get my ass kicked.

SATCH. Why don't you let them win, Big Man? They don't hit ya if they think they've whipped ya, know what I mean?

JOSH. I didn't mean to. It was a one-handed swing for crying out loud!

SATCH. You hit a homerun with one hand?

JOSH. It was a change-up in the eighth. Total accident, I swear. (T*hey stare at each other and then burst out laughing.*)

SATCH. Well alright, Big Man, meditate on this: me and you. We go to Brooklyn together. What do you say? No more barnstorming games, no more angry Southerners chasing us outta Tuscaloosa or Memphis or wherever—

JOSH. No more letting them white boys win. (*marvels at the opportunity for a moment then gets sarcastic*) I don't know… I mean I want to go with you, but you look like you slowing down there a little bit. I might have to go by myself.

SATCH. Yeah, I look slow and you look like you getting a little flabby there in the middle.

JOSH. Oh that? That's just them pork chops your wife been feeding me.

SATCH. Oh yeah, while I was over at your mama's house? She told me about that. On second thought, Paige and Gibson on the same team? I don't think the Big Apple is big enough.

JOSH. Yeah, you best keep your old crusty butt here in Missouri then.

RADIO. Rumors coming through that Rickey's negro baseball team, The Brown Dodgers, is rumored to be a Trojan horse for the notoriously controversial Mr. Rickey to sign colored players to his Major League team: the Brooklyn Dodgers.

(Transition to Josh's house at 2am. There is a loud knock on the door phone. Josh grabs his bat and cautiously answers the door.)

JOSH. Who is this?
SATCH. Big man, it's me.
JOSH. Satchel, I thought you was some angry mob.
SATCH. Big man, is some angry mob gonna knock? Hell, no.
JOSH. Ok, fine. But with what's been happening in Gainsville and—
SATCH. Look man, never mind that. I've been thinking about this Brown Dodgers thing. There is no money in negro league baseball, right?
JOSH. You got that right.
SATCH. So what do you think mister moneybags Branch Rickey is doing?
JOSH. Ok, I'll bite. Why is Branch Rickey sending scouts around?
SATCH. Maybe it ain't for the Brown Dodgers…maybe it's for the *Brooklyn* Dodgers.
JOSH. Come on, Satch, that's crazy.
SATCH. It's the only thing that makes sense. And I feel this, Big Man. I feel this.
JOSH. You better not be playing with me. If you are, them mobs are gonna be the last of your worries.
SATCH. I've been around this thing time and again, and I am sure that this is it. We going to the Major Leagues, baby. Big man, you still with me?
JOSH. I'm with you brother. All the way to the majors, Satch.

RADIO. Tension is mounting today after Mr. Rickey issued the following statement: "If a black boy

can make it on Okinawa, he can make it in Major League Baseball."

(Transition to Satchel's house, 2am. Satchel finds Josh drunk and beat up again on his front porch.)

SATCH. Josh? Josh, man? You ok?

JOSH. Hey, Satchel. Satchel Paige. I'm fine. I'm fine.

SATCH. I heard what happened. Did they hurt you real bad?

JOSH. Nah. Nothing some Kentucky bourbon couldn't make right as rain.

SATCH. Come on, man. (*helps him to his feet*)

JOSH. Hey, you know what Dizzy Dean said to me? Dizzy Dean said that homerun I hit off of him in Omaha in '36 was the best one he ever seen. He ain't never seen another like that. Said not even the white boys could have hit it better.

SATCH. You just keep it together, Big Man. Soon enough we'll get there and you won't have to deal with this anymore.

JOSH. My head hurts, Satch.

SATCH. Let's get you to a doctor.

JOSH. I ain't going to no doctor, Satch. (*suddenly angry*) Is the world really changing? You say it is. But I just don't even know. Does this life feel any different than my daddy's? Losing when they say lose, getting whooped for no damn reason, waiting for the chance to stop saying I'm sorry for being colored.

SATCH. Look, Truman's talking about integrating the military. How long you think it gonna be before it's our turn?

JOSH. You think it'll be us? I mean, what if it ain't? What if we're too old or too black or something? I just think…I don't know if I could handle that, man.

SATCH. Hey, I'm already old. Ain't no sense in worrying about getting older. And who else they gonna find who can hit like Josh Gibson?

JOSH. No one.

SATCH. That's right, no one. Not even the white boys could hit it better.

RADIO. The Brooklyn Dodgers have signed Jackie Robinson as the first colored baseball player in

Major League history. The young, articulate, former army officer comes as a surprise to many.

(Transition to clubhouse where Josh and Satch are listening to the radio.)

JOSH. (*frustrated, angry scream*) No!

SATCH. Jackie Robinson?

JOSH. They know! They know that if I go up there I'd break all those white boys' records. Babe Ruth… Gehrig…every damn one. They not gonna let that happen. They picked Robinson cause he can't do it.

SATCH. *(Is so shocked, he has no response.)*

JOSH. We did it all didn't we? Day in and day out. We've been spit on and cussed at and beat up. These scars, don't they buy me nothing? Not even one swing? And who the hell is Jackie Robinson?

SATCH. Why you asking me that?

JOSH. Cause you always got the answer.

SATCH. I ain't got no answer. I got no answer for you and no answer for me. I thought for sure them scouts were there to see—

JOSH. This is all your fault.

SATCH. My fault?

JOSH. You damn showboat. You make it the Satchel Paige Show and the rest of us can't even—

SATCH. Now wait just a damn minute.

JOSH. They didn't want some showboating old clown to be the first—

SATCH. …or a fat, sloppy, beat-up drunk. If you was the first, there's no way any one of us would have a chance!

JOSH. …

SATCH. Big man. Big man, I'm sorry.

JOSH. (*breaks down*) It's all I ever wanted. To prove I was as good as the white boys.

SATCH. You're not. Josh, you're better. You're the best player I ever seen. Maybe even including myself.

JOSH. You still think that?

SATCH. I always will, and someday those scars you got on you are gonna fade. They gonna disappear under them big league lights.

JOSH. And what if they don't?

SATCH. They will. You gonna be the first black man to hit a homerun outta Yankee Stadium, baby.

JOSH. You gonna be the one to throw it.

SATCH. This ain't nothing, Big Man. We rained out today, we'll play tomorrow. We are going to the majors. And someday everyone gonna know our names and know what we did.

JOSH. Even if they don't. I'll know what we did, and I'll be proud just the same.

RADIO. And today Jackie Robinson issued the statement, "I know I'm here now because of the great players who kept the dream alive. I may be the first to break the barrier, but it wasn't my work alone that got me here."

(Transition to a Negro League baseball game in Missouri. Satchel is on the pitching mound and Josh is approaching the plate as the batter.)

JOSH. You warmed up, old man?

SATCH. Big man, I ain't never cooled off.